

THE STORIES I MADE UP

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Every story I ever told you, written down.

JOSHUA CALEB GREEN

WORDS TO KEEP

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No part of the printed text of this book may be reproduced without permission from the publisher. Every story written into this book belongs to the person who told it, and to the person who asked for it.

This book is meant to be written in, drawn in, and read in the dark by flashlight.

Series: Words to Keep

If you're giving this book

Four things that make the difference between a book that fills up and one that sits by the bed.

1. Fill in the next page before you wrap it. Name the storyteller and the listener. Write where the stories usually happen.
2. Give it with a pen clipped to it. The first story should be written the same night.
3. Ask the listener to draw the cast first. Once the dragon has a face, the stories come.
4. Don't ask when it'll be full. Ask which one they told last night.

The storyteller

The listener

Where the stories usually happen

What time it usually is

These are yours.

Somewhere in your house there is a dragon nobody else has ever heard of. A truck that talks. A girl who is also, for reasons that made sense at the time, a sandwich. You made them up at nine o'clock at night with one hand on a small back, and you have told them fifty times, and you could not repeat one of them now if you tried.

That's what this book is for. Not the stories in other books. Yours.

You don't have to write them well. Write them the way you tell them, with the part you always forget and the ending that changes. Write the ones that are two sentences long. Write the one that only works if you do the voice, and then write what the voice was.

Someday the person you told them to will be taller than you, and will want to know whether the dragon was ever really afraid of the stairs. This is where they'll find out.

How to use this book

One story to a spread. Give it a title, even if the title is The Truck One.

Write the date you first told it, if you remember. If you don't, write the year and guess.

Tick a box every time it's asked for. The one with the most ticks goes in the back of the book, the long way.

Let the listener draw. There's a box on every story for that, and eight pages at the front for the cast.

Write in pen, in pencil, in crayon. Write in the dark if you have to.

Abandoned stories count. So do stories that were mostly a list of animals.

The rules

There aren't any. But since you asked:

Bad stories count.

Stories you borrowed from a movie and then made better count.

If the listener remembers it differently, the listener is right.

You are allowed to write the ending you never got to.

PART ONE

The Cast

Every storyteller has a company. The ones who turn up whether you planned them or not. The dragon. The truck. The small brave thing that is always, somehow, the listener.

Put them here first, so the stories have somewhere to live. Let the listener draw them. They know what the dragon looks like better than you do.

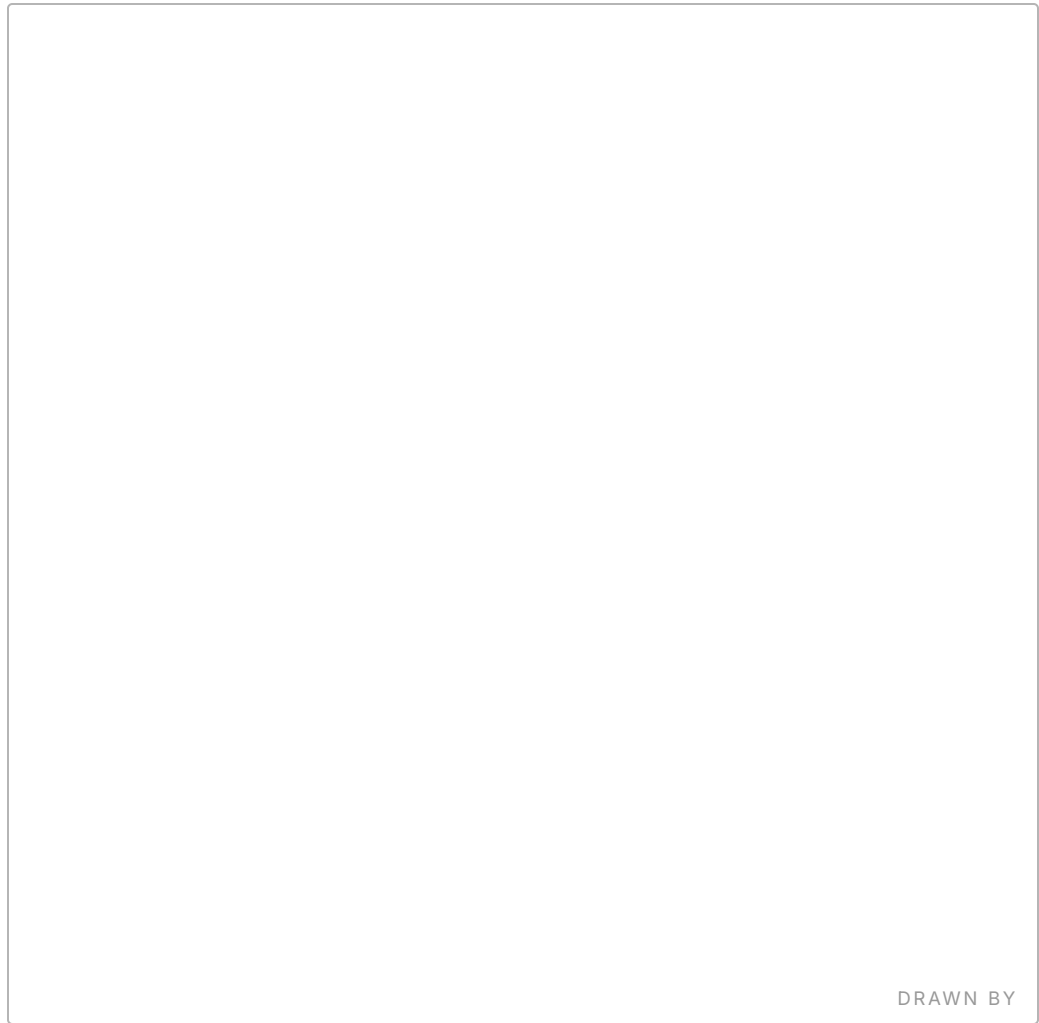
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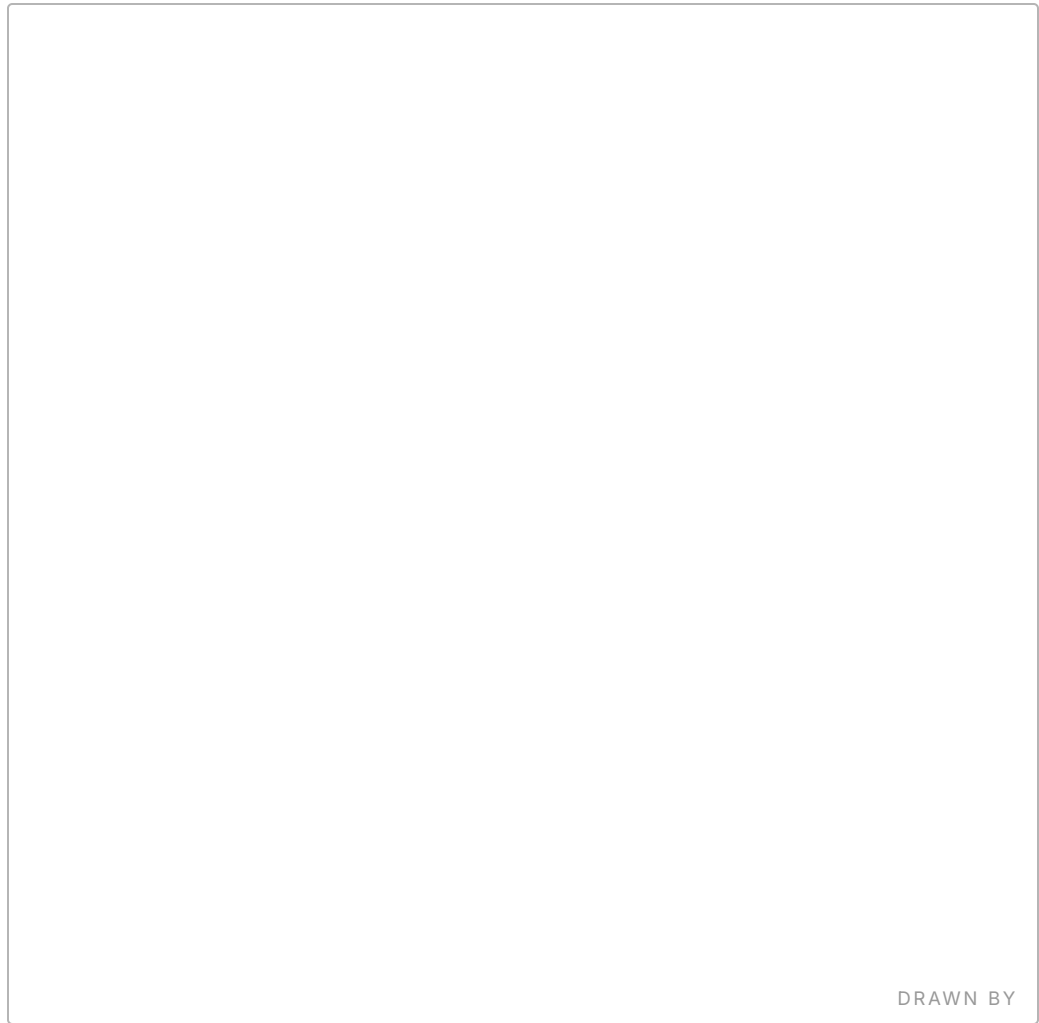
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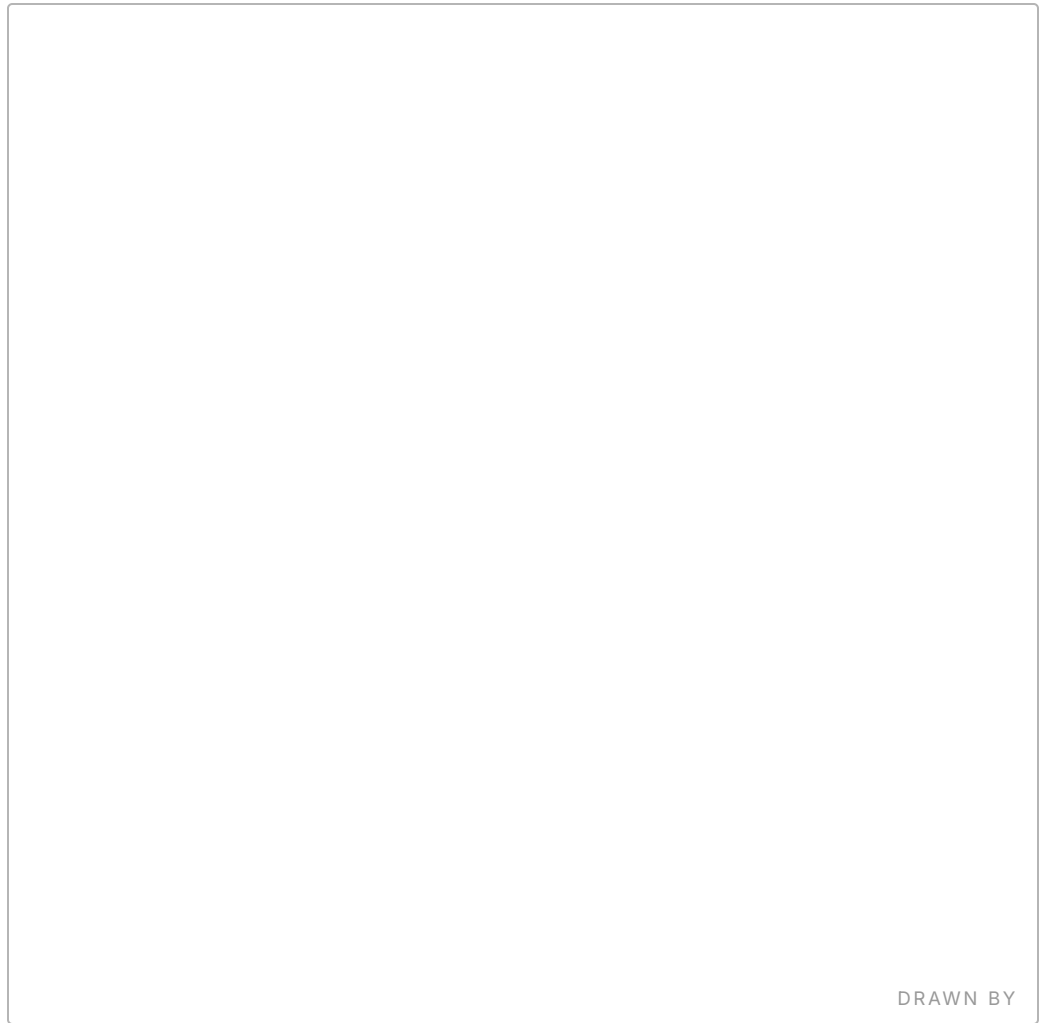
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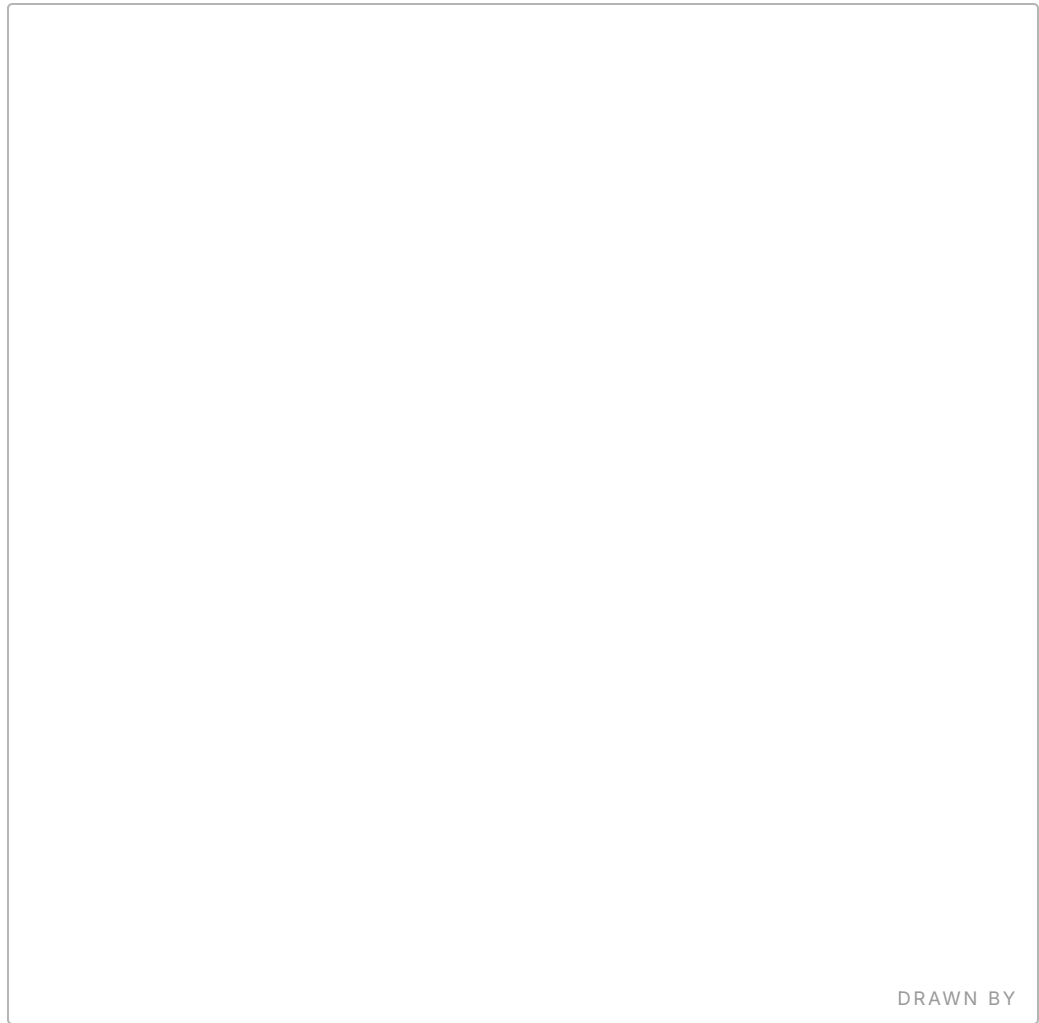
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Where the stories happened

The bed. The car. The tent. The waiting room. Draw them or write them, and what time it usually was.



How we started, how we ended

How the stories always began

How they always ended

The voice I did

What you said when you wanted another one

For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

PART TWO

The Stories

Thirty-six of them, or however many there were. One to a spread.

If you can't remember how one started, start in the middle.
That's how you told it.

TITLE

FIRST TOLD

TOLD TO

TIMES ASKED FOR

[illegible]

TITLE

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For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

PART THREE

The Ones We Kept

Some stories got told a hundred times. Some got told once and never again, because somebody fell asleep before the end.

Both go here.

The one you always asked for

Write it the long way, with everything in it.

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Stories that never got finished

Where they stopped, and where they were going.

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This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are approximately 20 lines visible. The paper has a slight shadow on the right side, suggesting it's resting on a surface.

Stories you made up yourself

For the listener. Your stories, in your own hand, at any age.

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Things you said that went into the stories

A word you got wrong that became a character's name.

The thing you were scared of that week.

The animal you insisted on.

The rule you added. (The dragon can't fly on Tuesdays.)

The ending you demanded.

The question you asked in the middle.

For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

What I remember about these

For the listener, years from now. Which ones you remember. Which ones you didn't know were made up. Which ones you've told your own kids.

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The last one

A story they haven't heard yet, written now, for a night you might not be there. Any length.

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For the one reading this

You are holding the stories someone made up for you, one at a time, in the dark, because you asked. Nobody else has ever heard them. That's what makes them yours.

The list

Write each story's title next to its page, so anyone can find it again.

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